

PAUSE. PIVOT. POINT.

*A Framework for Reaching
the Students Your School
Almost Lost*

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THE DREAM SHAKE



The Dream Shake is the Framework.

PAUSE

*The hesitation.
Reaction avoided.*

PIVOT

*The spin move.
Action taken.*

POINT

*The basket.
The lesson beneath.*

*Hakeem didn't react. He read. He moved. He scored.
That's what great educators do every single day.*

You know this student.

The one who's been written off.

Cycled through.

Given up on before they ever walked into your room.

You chose this work anyway.

But surviving the day isn't the same as reaching them.

We Have to Be the Difference.

The only thing different cannot be the room.

Smaller building, smaller roster, different address — that is a relocation, not an intervention.

WHAT CHANGED FOR THEM

A new building.
Fewer kids in the room.
A new bell schedule.
A new label on the door.

WHAT HAS TO CHANGE IN US

How we respond in hard moments.
Who speaks first — stigma or dignity.
Whether we react or read.
Whether the lesson is the lesson, or the child.

If we do the same thing with fewer kids, we have only built a smaller version of the place that already failed them.

Putnam Heights Academy

Oklahoma City Public Schools · Alternative Behavioral School

150

Students
Grades 5-12

27

Years in
Public Education

100%

Dignity
First Policy

"I did not want stigma to speak first. I wanted dignity to speak first."

The Motto

**I have value.
My life has a purpose.
I will succeed.**

These words are not decoration. They are a sequence.

The Pause. Pivot. Point. Framework

PAUSE

Reaction avoided.

The space between what a student does and what you do next. It is not silence. It is strategy.

PIVOT

Action taken.

A deliberate redirection that bypasses the ego and opens a door. Not appeasement — the opposite of it.

POINT

The lesson beneath.

What the moment was actually about. The teaching that happens when everything else is out of the way.

PAUSE

REACTION AVOIDED.

What Is the Pause?

A student slams a book down. Walks out. Says something disrespectful.

Your nervous system wants to react. That is biology.

The Pause is the moment between stimulus and response where you choose what kind of educator you are going to be right now.

It is not weakness. It is the first move.

Pause in Practice

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Lower your voice instead of raising it

Take a physical step back

Redirect attention to the room before re-engaging the student

Buy yourself 10 seconds before you say anything

WHAT IT IS NOT

Backing down

Ignoring the behavior

Letting it go

Appeasement

The Pause is a skill. It gets better with practice — and it is never the final move.

The Cost of Not Pausing

- The student wins the moment — and they know it.
- The audience — every other kid in the room — watches you lose the room.
- You've confirmed that emotion, not strategy, runs the class.
- You spend the next 20 minutes managing the aftermath instead of teaching.
- You may never recover their trust.

STORY ONE · THE PAUSE

THE HIGHWAY.

My grandfather, and the difference between talking and moving.

“

**You can't say anything crazier.
You have to move differently.**

— Shane Nelson, on his grandfather

PIVOT

ACTION TAKEN.

What Is the Pivot?

The Pivot is the deliberate move you make after the Pause. It is not a reaction. It is a choice.

The Pivot redirects without triggering the student's ego defense system. It reads the student, finds a door that's open, and walks through it — instead of kicking down the one that's locked.

Hakeem didn't charge at the defender. He read the defender and moved where there was space.

Reading the Student

Every student is a banana at a different stage of ripeness.

Your job is not to wish they were a different banana.

Your job is to handle the one in front of you.

THE REDIRECT IN ACTION

A student acting out in the office. Instead of confronting the behavior head-on, I called him out for talking to three girls today. He got embarrassed. Then inflated. Then he sat down.

No lecture. No power struggle. No anger. The behavior redirected without ever triggering his ego defense. That is the Pivot.

STORY TWO · THE PIVOT

GRADUATION MORNING.

Gabriel, and taking myself out of the equation.

“

**I took myself out of the
equation on purpose.**

— Shane Nelson, on Gabriel

The Pivot Is NOT Appeasement

APPEASEMENT	THE PIVOT
Makes deals to end conflict	Moves with intention to teach through conflict
Student wins, educator loses	Neither wins — learning wins
Buys silence with surrender	Buys engagement with strategy
Says: you are in charge	Says: I see you, and I'm still here
Easier now — costs more later	Harder now — pays more later

POINT

THE LESSON BENEATH.

What Is the Point?

The Point is what the moment was actually about. Not the behavior you redirected. Not the conflict you navigated.

It is the lesson that only became possible because you paused and pivoted — the thing the child carries out of your room.

The point of the lesson is never the lesson.

The point of the lesson is the child.

STORY THREE · THE POINT

THE CAFETERIA.

Axzavier, a small win, and an open ending.

“

**He came to summer school.
He didn't finish.
And I'm still there.**

— Shane Nelson, on Axxavier

What the Point Sounds Like

SAY THIS

"I love the effort you made on this."

"I saw you spend 40 straight minutes
nose-deep in that test."

"I love your growth."

NOT THIS

"Great job getting 100."

"I'm glad you got the right answer."

"You achieved perfection."

What we compliment, we grow. What we grow, we keep.

Small wins are the whole game: a kid at the bus stop at 6:30 with nobody making him go · two students working as partners without being told · a hand raised instead of a desk flipped · a question asked · showing up.

Build Your Own Pause. Pivot. Point.

Pair up — a friend or a stranger. You have about 7 minutes.

01

Pick one small, real situation you deal with often — phones out during instructions, three kids crammed in one bathroom stall, a student who won't sit down.

02

Write your own Event, Pause, Pivot and Point. This is not a group answer. Everyone fills in their own.

03

Trade with your partner. Say out loud what you would actually pivot to. That is the practice.

The only thing you cannot do is write a pivot you would never actually make.

One Example, Filled In

EVENT	THE PAUSE	THE PIVOT	THE POINT
<i>What happened</i> Phones out during instructions.	<i>What most people do</i> “Put it away!” — raised voice, instant power struggle.	<i>What I will do</i> Name what I see. Redirect to the task, not the phone.	<i>My goal — not theirs</i> Get them back on task — not prove who's in charge.

Now build one of your own — on paper, with your partner. · 7 minutes.

The Forgotten Ones

They are quiet. They blend in.

They have learned to survive without asking for much.

They have been mislabeled, underestimated, or never truly seen.

The forgotten ones you pour into every day deserve the best version of you — not the version that showed up after everyone else already took their share.

Some of them are in your building right now.

You Leave With This Monday.

PAUSE

Before you respond to a hard moment, take one breath. Lower your voice instead of raising it. Buy yourself 10 seconds.

PIVOT

Choose a door that's open. Find the thing they care about. Redirect without triggering the ego. Or hand it to someone else.

POINT

After the storm, name what happened. Give them something to hold. Compliment the effort, not the result.

Apply it once this week. Tell a colleague. Watch what changes.

They need to hear it from you.

**I have value.
My life has a purpose.
I will succeed.**

That is the Point.

PAUSE. PIVOT. POINT.

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“See the invisible. Honor the story. Build with meaning.”